

ENTRY PRINCIPLE

Earn the right to simplify.

The first objective is not to install a prebuilt operating system. It is to learn where leaders already have trust, where information duplicates, where decisions age, and what teams must do differently for a new mechanism to be worth keeping.

Operating assumptions to test

Visibility is fragmented

Hypothesis: commitment confidence and cross-functional constraints are visible in different places and at different cadences.

Authority is mostly clear—until it crosses boundaries

Hypothesis: local decision rights work, but cross-business tradeoffs and escalations create latency.

Meeting preparation carries hidden burden

Hypothesis: duplicate decks and reconciliation consume attention that should go to decisions.

Repeated recovery contains reusable learning

Hypothesis: recurring exceptions are not always converted into standards or planning assumptions.

Change burden

Who	What changes	Adoption safeguard
Executives	Agree on thresholds and retire low-value reporting.	Measure decision quality and meeting burden, not tool usage.
Function leaders	Expose confidence and constraints earlier.	Keep ownership close to the work.
Frontline and field	Signal exceptions in a common language.	Reuse existing sources and reduce duplicate entry.
Governance functions	Define non-negotiable boundaries and escalation paths.	Preserve independent technical and regulatory authority.

Listening architecture

Perspective	What I need to learn	Evidence to examine
Executive sponsor	Where attention is consumed, where confidence is weakest, and what year-one success means.	Leadership agendas, recurring escalations, commitment reviews, and unresolved decisions.
Program and function leaders	Where dependencies cross boundaries and which mechanisms already work.	Source systems, milestone logic, constraint logs, recovery actions, and handoffs.
Frontline, field, and governance experts	What signals arrive late, what duplicate work costs, and which authority boundaries cannot blur.	Operating rhythms, exception paths, quality/regulatory gates, and meeting preparation.

PHASE 1 + PHASE 2

Observe the work. Build one shared view.

0–30 · Observe the work

Listen

Shadow executive reviews, customer and field rhythms, program forums, operations reviews, and cross-functional escalations.

Map

Decision rights, trusted sources, shadow decks, recurring friction, dependencies, and adoption burden.

Test assumptions

Identify where information is late, duplicated, disputed, or disconnected from a decision.

Protect what works

Document existing mechanisms leaders trust before proposing changes.

Outputs

- Stakeholder and decision-rights map
- Executive-cadence inventory
- Trusted-source and shadow-system map
- Top recurring friction hypotheses
- Baseline for meeting preparation and decision aging

31–60 · Build the shared view

Choose one bounded pilot

Select a portfolio or forum where cross-functional commitment confidence matters and leadership sponsorship is real.

Reuse existing data

Prototype the commitment map and constraint ledger without asking teams to create another reporting layer.

Define thresholds

Draft escalation rules with technical, safety, quality, regulatory, and business leaders.

Clarify ownership

Assign closure, not merely attendance, for decisions and recovery actions.

Outputs

- Commitment/dependency pilot
- Constraint aging view
- Draft escalation thresholds
- Decision-rights exceptions log
- Pilot adoption agreement

Pilot selection gates

Consequential	The pilot affects a real commitment and has enough friction to teach something useful.
Bounded	Scope, owner, source data, forum, and decision rights can be named.
Sponsored	A leader will use the output to make or route an actual decision.
Reversible	The mechanism can be stopped without creating a shadow system or reporting obligation.

PHASE 3 + PHASE 4

Test the cadence. Scale only what improves decisions.

61–90 · Test decision cadence

Run the pilot

Use the envelope in one bounded leadership forum with visible commitments and real cross-functional dependencies.

Measure behavior

Track decision age, constraint aging, preparation burden, confidence movement, and closure.

Audit signal-to-action

Check whether critical signals changed a decision, allocation, escalation, or standard.

Correct adoption friction

Remove duplicate fields, unclear ownership, or thresholds that generate noise.

Outputs

- Decision log and aging
- Before/after meeting-burden comparison
- Signal-to-action audit
- Pilot scorecard
- Stop / adjust / scale recommendation

91–120 · Scale what proves useful

Standardize the minimum

Keep only the shared language, thresholds, and source rules needed for cross-boundary decisions.

Hand ownership toward the work

Function leaders and teams own content; the Chief of Staff owns coherence and executive mechanism health.

Retire burden

Stop duplicate reviews and reporting that do not change decisions.

Compound learning

Convert recurring causes into standards, planning assumptions, and reusable playbooks.

Outputs

- Operating-envelope playbook
- Ownership and governance model
- Stop/start/continue review
- Expansion criteria
- Year-one outcome scorecard

Success at day 120

One bounded mechanism has either proven useful or been stopped quickly. Leaders have clearer decision rights, teams carry less duplicate reporting burden, and the next scaling decision is based on evidence rather than enthusiasm.